

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1990-02-12

To the bahá'ís of the world

1 with feelings of thankfulness and joy we announce an achievement of
2 immense importance to the accelerating progress of the cause of bahá'u'lláh.

The university of maryland and the National Spiritual Assembly of the

3 bahá'ís of the united States recently signed a memorandum of understand-
4 ing, establishing "The bahá'í chair for world peace" at that university's

center for international development and conflict management. The

5 stated purpose of the chair is "to conduct and publish research, design
6 courses and conduct seminars in the field of bahá'í studies and world peace
7 within an interdisciplinary context; to initiate public forums for discuss-
8 entitled The Promise of World Peace; and to establish academic linkages with
9 and provide technical assistance to bahá'í institutions in the fields of peace

education and international development."

10 This first initiative by a well-founded, significant institution of higher
11 learning to formulate such a serious program of bahá'í studies is a direct
12 response to the peace Statement, as is borne out by a letter addressed to us
13 by the director of the center for international development and conflict
14 management in which he said: " with this letter i am answering on behalf
15 of cidcm and the university of maryland your call: 'i f the bahá'í experi-
16 ence can contribute in whatever measure to reinforcing hope in the unity of the
human race, we are happy to offer it as a model for study.'"

17 fully cognizant of bahá'u'lláh's praise of knowledge as "wings to man's
18 life" and of the importance which he assigns to its acquisition; of 'Abdu'l-
19 bahá's advice that we should "seek to impart the message to influential per-
20 sons and become a cause of guidance to the learned and distinguished"; and of
Shoghi effendi's call for a "resolute attempt" to reinforce measures "for

21 the establishment of closer contact with the leaders of public thought, with
22 colleges and universities,” we hail this seminal development both as a mark
23 of the faith’s emergence from obscurity and as the harbinger of that day
24 when hosts of scholars will devote their energies to the exploration, exposi-
25 tion and defense of the dynamic principles animating the world order of 85.1

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86 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

87 15bahá’u’lláh, thereby fulfilling the need identified by the beloved guardian

88 for “well-read and well-educated people, capable of correlating our teach-

89 ings to the current thoughts of the leaders of society.”85-1 on that day, we

90 shall witness an expansion and consolidation of the community as has not yet been
experienced.

may the blessed beauty enable the new bahá’í chair for world peace to

91 achieve its laudable purpose; may he shower upon all who support it his

92 abundant confirmations.

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Fiftieth Anniversary of the Passing of May Maxwell

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]